

Cookie clicker Progression and Pacing Analysis

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The mechanism is basically one click for a cookie. As you get more cookies, you can buy machines to make your CPS (cookies per second) higher and automate the cookie production process. New systems appear usually after you have 10-ish machines at this level. So for example, when you buy 10 farms, you will likely be able to easily collect enough cookies to buy mine. These machines encourage players to let the machines produce cookies automatically, instead of clicking a mouse. This helps make the player more willing to continue the game, since no one likes to click the mouse all the time. I feel the progression is well-balanced, because I can get to the next system in less than 5 minutes, so I don't feel bored. What kept me engaged is that the number is continuously increasing. If I wait one more second, the number can grow up even more.... Then I don't want to close the window.

At the beginning, when I finally had a farm to produce cookies, I took a long breath because now the automated cookie production is fast enough that I don't have to click the mouse anymore. Then at the later stage where I have a factory, I get to let this game run backstage. I'm pretty excited to see how much more cookie I have when I checked. However, when my number of cookies gets to 1 million, I'm not as satisfied as before because now I can't see the number growing rapidly. (It is abbreviated as 1.xx million in the game).

To maintain satisfaction, the game could introduce stronger and more varied forms of feedback at higher numbers. For example, it could introduce milestone-based rewards that trigger special events or unique upgrades whenever players reach major thresholds, giving a clear sense of achievement beyond just the number increasing. Additionally, new long-term progression systems such as prestige layers or unlockable worlds could help break up the sense of repetition and provide fresh goals.